

A young woman with blonde hair, wearing a white t-shirt and jeans, is smiling and holding a green ping pong ball. She is standing behind a bar counter where two red plastic cups are placed on a light-up surface. The background is a dimly lit bar with colorful neon lights and a zigzag pattern overlay on the left side.

COMPETITIVE SOCIALISING

Winning a new
customer occasion

Introduction

“

Competitive socialising is a phrase on a lot of industry lips, at present, as this subset of the hospitality industry continues to outperform many of its more ‘traditional’ counterparts. So what's the secret of its success? From a customer perspective, the occasion ticks a lot of boxes in terms of wider consumer trends, many of which have been exacerbated by the recent pandemic and subsequent lockdowns.

Customers are demanding more from the hospitality venues they visit, wanting memorable experiences which are less easy to replicate at home. For many, this means having a perfectly poured draft pint, an expertly made cocktail or a sumptuous roast. However, many customers are expecting more than just good drinks, good food and a comfortable seat. Creating memories and ‘social media moments’ is the focus of the younger generations. Ultimately, we want a memorable experience. We want to be entertained.

”

Blake Gladman
Strategy & Insight Director

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The data from KAM that features in this report is taken from a research study commissioned exclusively for this report (KAM - Competitive Socialising Report 2022). This research was a nationally representative survey of UK adults (18+), sample size 500, survey conducted January 2022).

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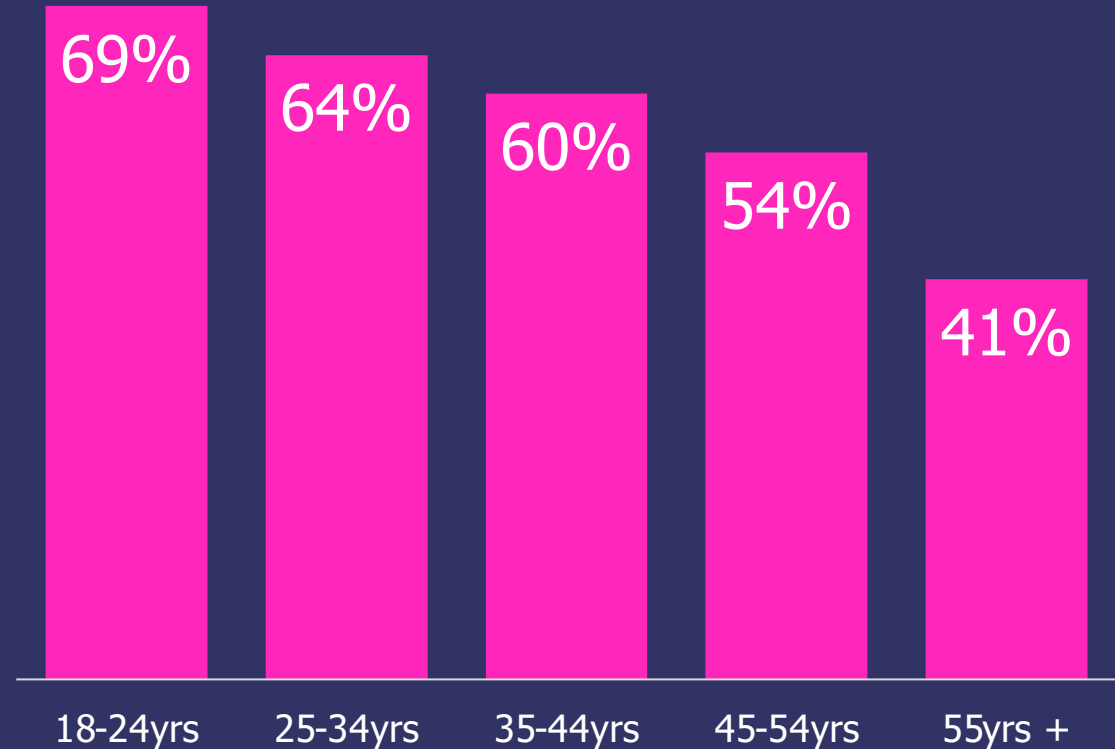
Why experience is key...

What are 2022 customers looking for from our venues?

88%

“I want pubs/bars to provide me with an experience I can't get at home”

**“I would rather
spend money on
experiences
compared with
physical goods”**



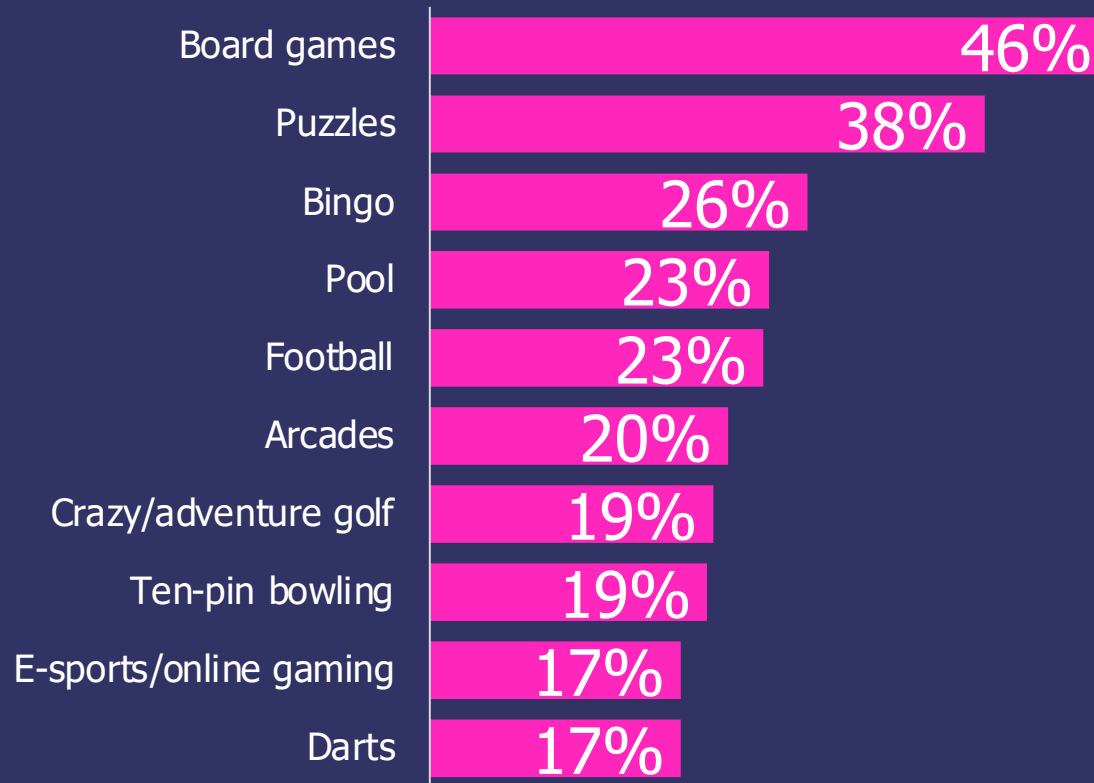
Why focus on experience over material goods?

There are three key factors as to why people are increasingly focussing on experience over material goods...these are particularly applicable to Gen Z and Millennials but hold true amongst older consumers too:

1. **A stronger link to happiness.** Consumers are much more likely to like material goods that they've purchased less and less over time. Whereas they are much more likely to look back increasingly fondly on experiences. A memory of an experience often gets better and better in our mind over time, leading to greater feelings of happiness.
2. **The quest for "likes."** Social media has obviously accelerated the growing demand for experiences. The quest for likes requires a constant stream of new shareable content in the form of stories and pictures.
3. **FOMO! A fear of missing out.** Keeping up with the Joneses used to be about wanting to own the same expensive products your friends or Neighbours did. This anxiety is so deeply embedded in the social fibre of millennials that they have given it a nickname: FOMO. The term was even added to the *Oxford English Dictionary* back in 2013.



What leisure activities are most popular?



“A lot of these activities are becoming increasingly popular with Gen Z and Millennials. With 48% of Millennials playing board games and 41% of Gen Z doing puzzles. It just shows that ‘experiential’ doesn’t necessarily mean high-tech.”

Competitive Socialising

A look at the dedicated venues

Footfall remains an issue for hospitality

10%
Hospitality average



2%
Experiential/
Competitive
Socialising Venues



According to Wireless Social, hospitality footfall remains approx. 10% down on average.

(Comparing Feb 2020 to Dec 2021, based on logins at venues)

But interestingly, footfall at dedicated competitive socializing venues are less than 2% down.

The experiential venues seem to be bouncing back slightly faster.



And experiential and competitive socialising venue enquires are rising fast!



408%

Experiential/
Competitive
Socialising Venues

Data from Bums on Seats shows that experiential/competitive socialising venues have seen a 408% increase in enquiries in January compared with mid-December, showing an increase in consumer confidence in the channel as a whole, but also specifically in this area as this increase in enquiries is higher than other hospitality sectors.

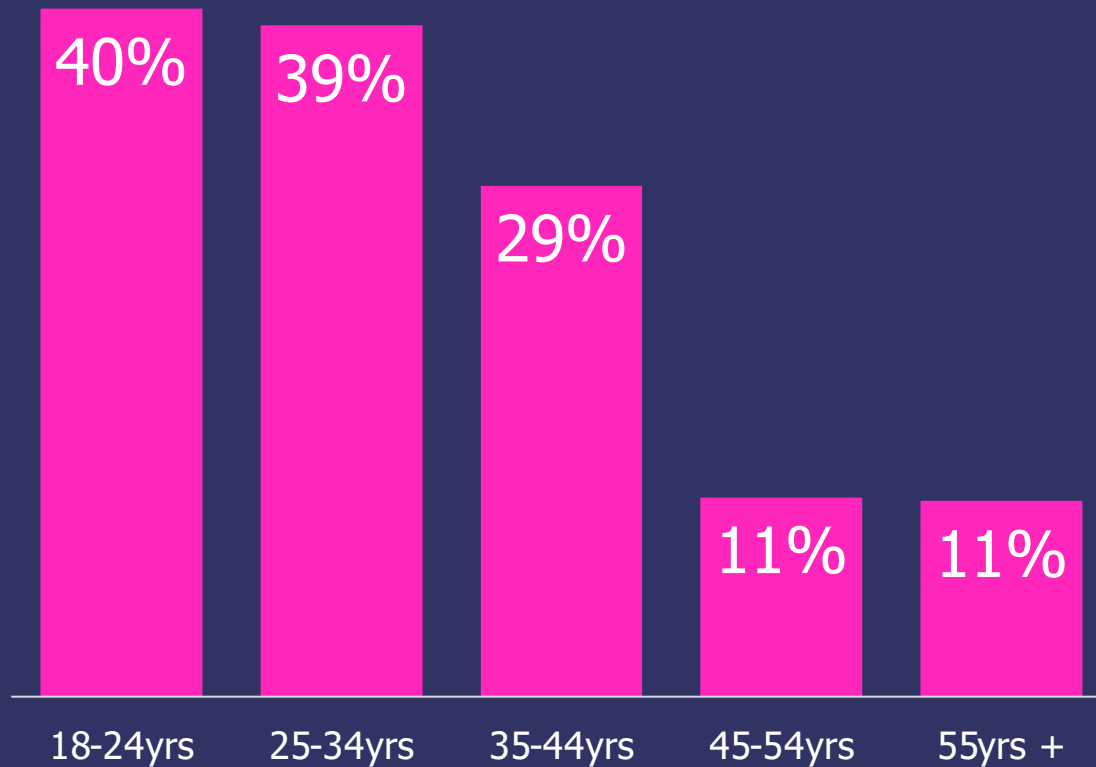
Source: Bums on Seats

BUMS  SEATS



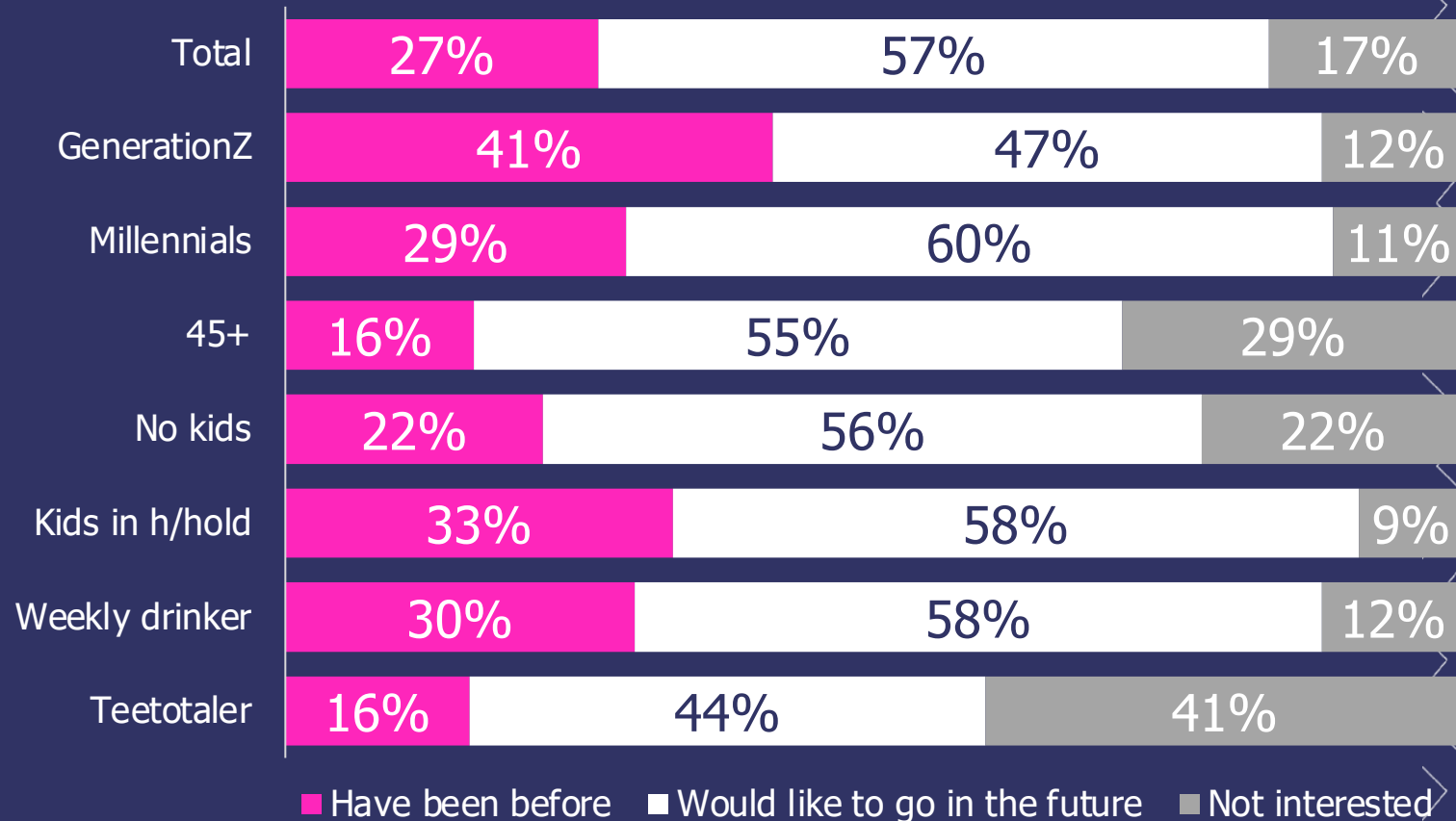
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Have the general public heard of the term 'competitive socialising'?



“Awareness is significantly higher amongst Gen Z and Millennials. Location also plays a significant role with 48% of Londoners aware compared to just 13% in Scotland and 15% in East Anglia. Is there a London/city bubble?”

What is the opportunity for competitive socialising venues?



Who is the current 'competitive socialising' customer?

+15%p Gen Z
+14%p Londoners
+7%p Parents
+4%p Males
+3%p Regular drinkers

"Competitive socialising customers 'over-index' in the above demographic profiles. With Gen Z and London, and parents to a lesser extent, being significant drivers for the increased demand for competitive socialising."



53%

**“I’m visiting more competitive
socialising venues now
compared to 2 years ago”**

(67% Gen Z. 64% parents)

Occasions that drive visits to competitive socialising venues



The demand and opportunity is big

At present it may be true, in part, that Gen Z and Millennials are driving a significant part of the growth we are seeing in competitive socialising. However, parents are also playing a role (bringing back the games they perhaps played in their youth, which may have gone out of fashion)- after all, keeping the kids busy and happy whilst out is every parents' aim. We are also seeing demand from older age groups, with 55% of 45+ year-olds saying that they are interested in going to a competitive socialising venue in the future.

It's not just special occasions which are driving footfall. Competitive socialising venues are now becoming places which people will visit regularly as they catch up with friends and have fun with their family. They have entered into the portfolio of venues, alongside traditional pubs and bars, as consumers look for something that little bit different- an experience that they can less easily replicate at home.

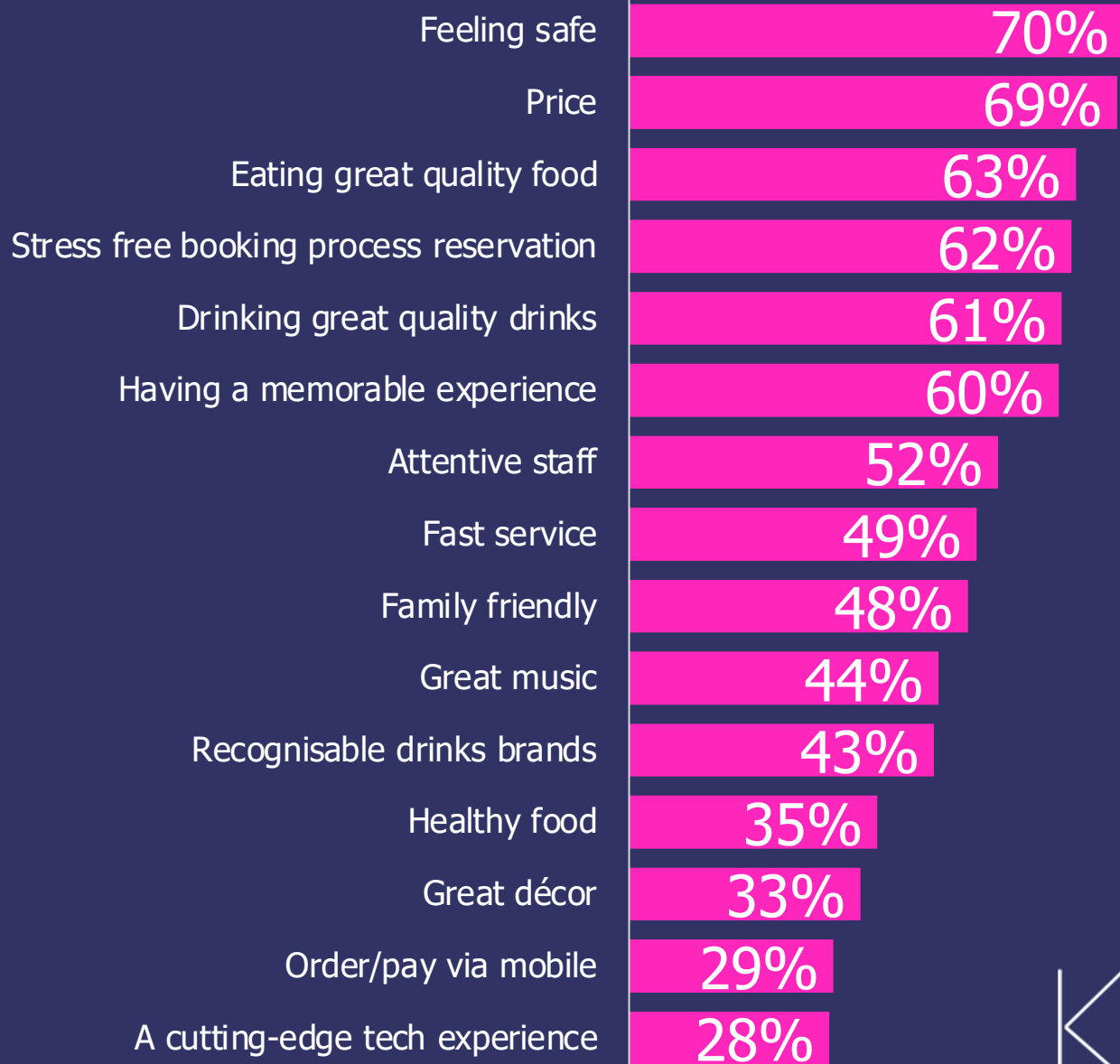


The in-venue experience

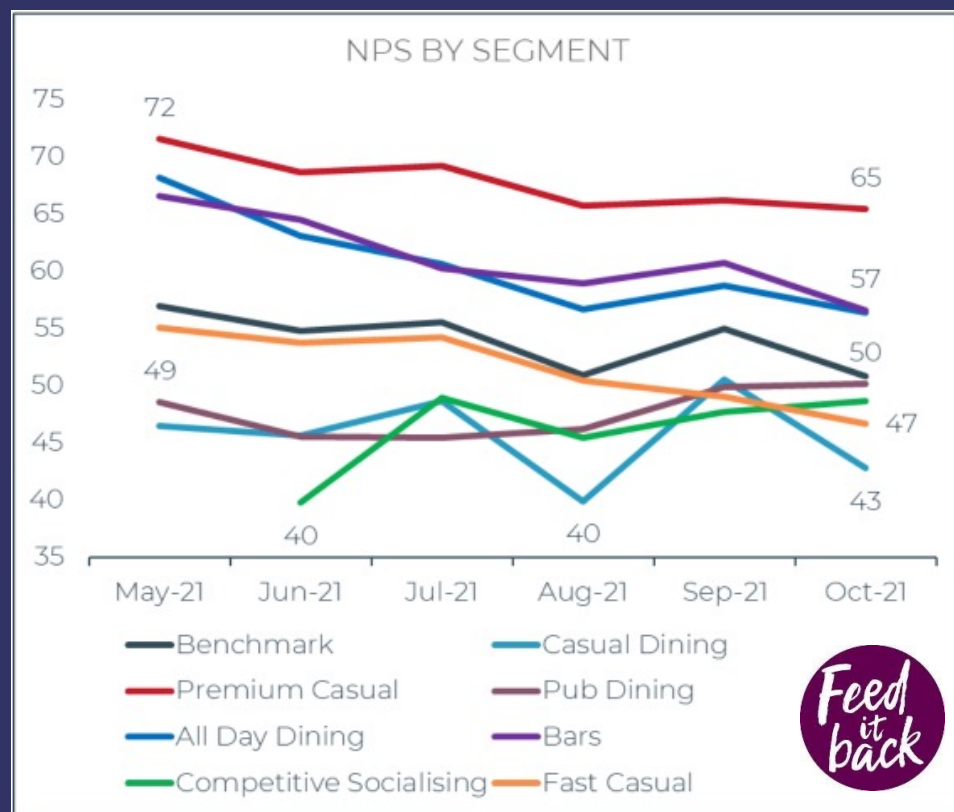
Driving footfall and spend with
competitive socialising

What customers want from a competitive socialising venue

“The customer experience, value for money and quality of staff still feature highly – just like in any other hospitality venue. Don’t forget the basics!”



How are these venues doing?



“Put simply, they’re growing in numbers. We’ve already seen the Wireless Social footfall figures that tell us they’re bouncing back quicker compared with other outlet types. But we can take a look at the latest figures shared by Feed It Back to show that customers are not 100% satisfied with this growing sector.

Compared with other hospitality segments, Competitive Socialising venues (green) currently score below average when it comes to NPS.” Customers expect more from these exciting venues.

Speed of service is the biggest frustration in competitive socialising venues

Share of complaints

Speed of service 34%

Value for money 28%

Activity/game issues 13%

Staff attitude 11%

“Looking at Feed It Back figures, ‘Speed of Service’ is a rising complaint topic across the industry. Improving service timings and managing expectations will be key to driving guest satisfaction going forward. As with hospitality in general, delivering on the basics is key, and it may be easier to lose sight of this when focussing on high-tech entertainment. However, these results suggest that those basics remain a fundamental part of the offering for customers.”

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Coming out of the pandemic, delivering an unforgettable experience has never been so important. The biggest challenge we now have is getting people out of their home and away from Netflix and Deliveroo. We really need to offer so much more than food and drink.

//

Charles Gilks
Founder • Inception Group

Quote from Competitive Socialising: Power of Play 2022 presentation



55%

"I'm more likely to want street-food style dining options when in a competitive socialising venue (compared to a standard venue)"

46%

"I'm more likely to want food I can eat with my hands"

43%

"I'm more likely to want shareable food"



46%

"I'm more likely to want cocktails when in a competitive socialising venue (compared to a standard venue)"

32%

"I'm more likely to want sharing jugs of cocktails"



32%

"I'm more likely to want sharing buckets of beers"

25%

"I'm more likely to want low/no alcohol alternatives"



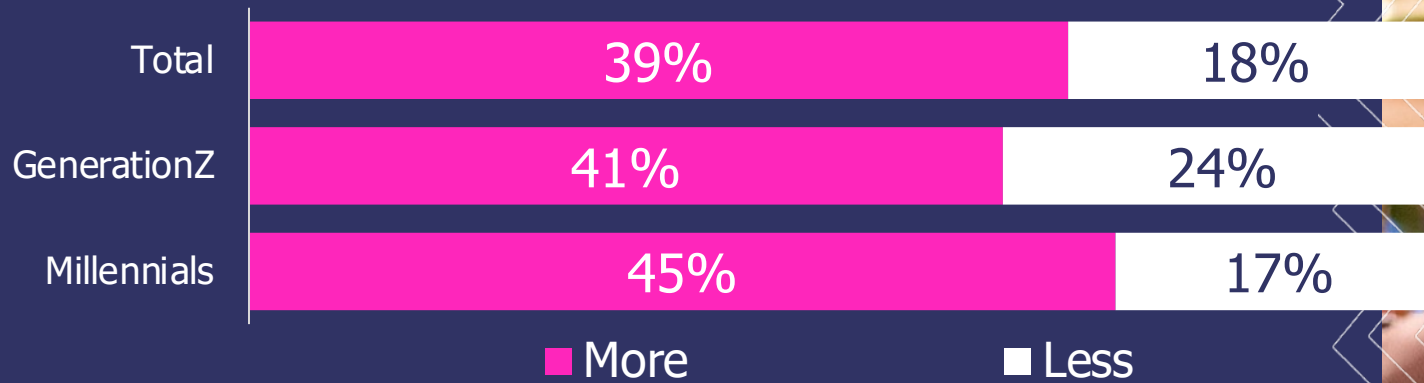
Sharing is caring when it comes to food and drinks

"There is a clear increase in demand from customers for food that is both easy to eat (with their hands!) and easy to share. The same goes for drinks, with an increase in likelihood to order sharing buckets of beers and sharing cocktails. The increase in demand for cocktails and street food in particular lends greater credence to the fact that customers are more likely to be looking to extend their 'experiential' experiences beyond the games they play and into the food and drink they consume also."

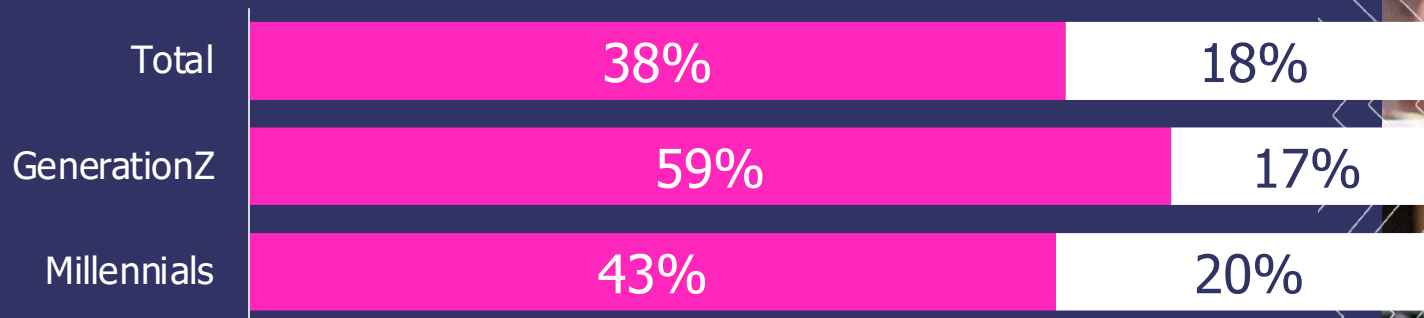


Driving incremental spend

Would you spend more on food? (compared to a standard venue)



Would you spend more on drinks? (compared to a standard venue)



78%

Of parents would be likely to visit competitive socialising venues with their children



Top tips for an unforgettable experience

- Create an **immersive and shareable** experience (plan organic photo opportunities)
- Prioritise customer **engagement—not sales**
- **Stimulate** your customers' senses
- Defy customer expectations (**surprise** and delight)
- Leverage in-venue events and services (**change it up**)
- Ensure the customer experience addresses **consumer needs**



The opportunity for wider hospitality

The role competitive socialising can play in driving new footfall to 'traditional' pubs and bars

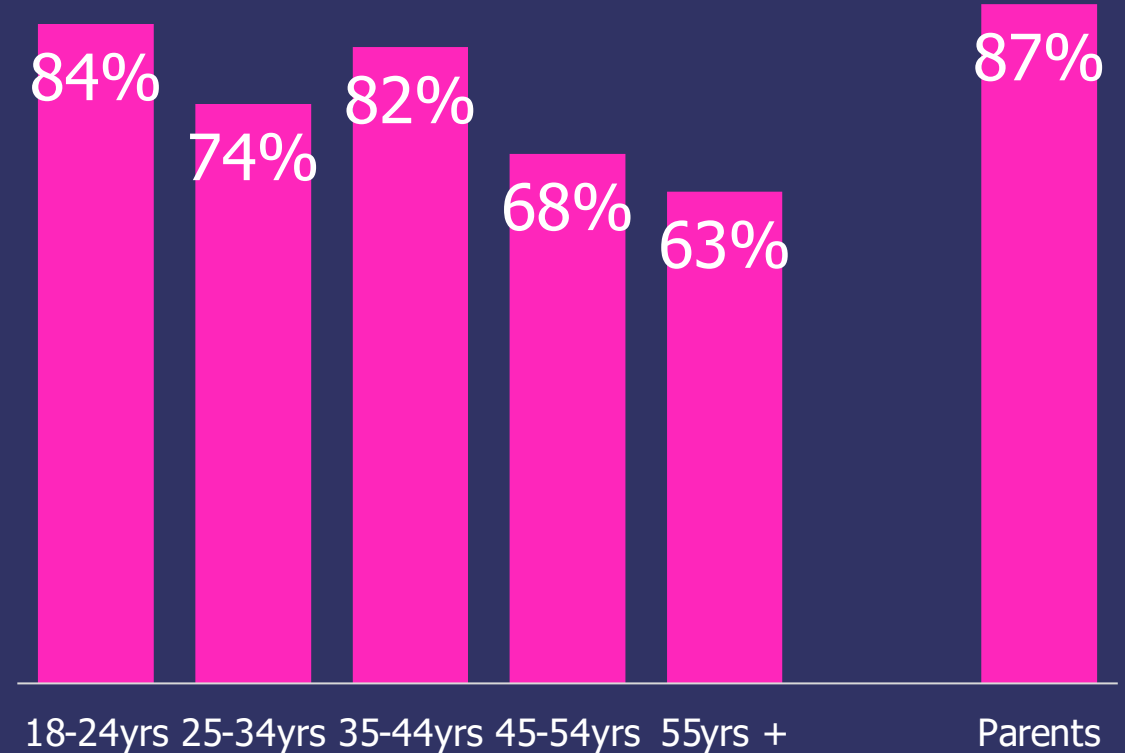
74%

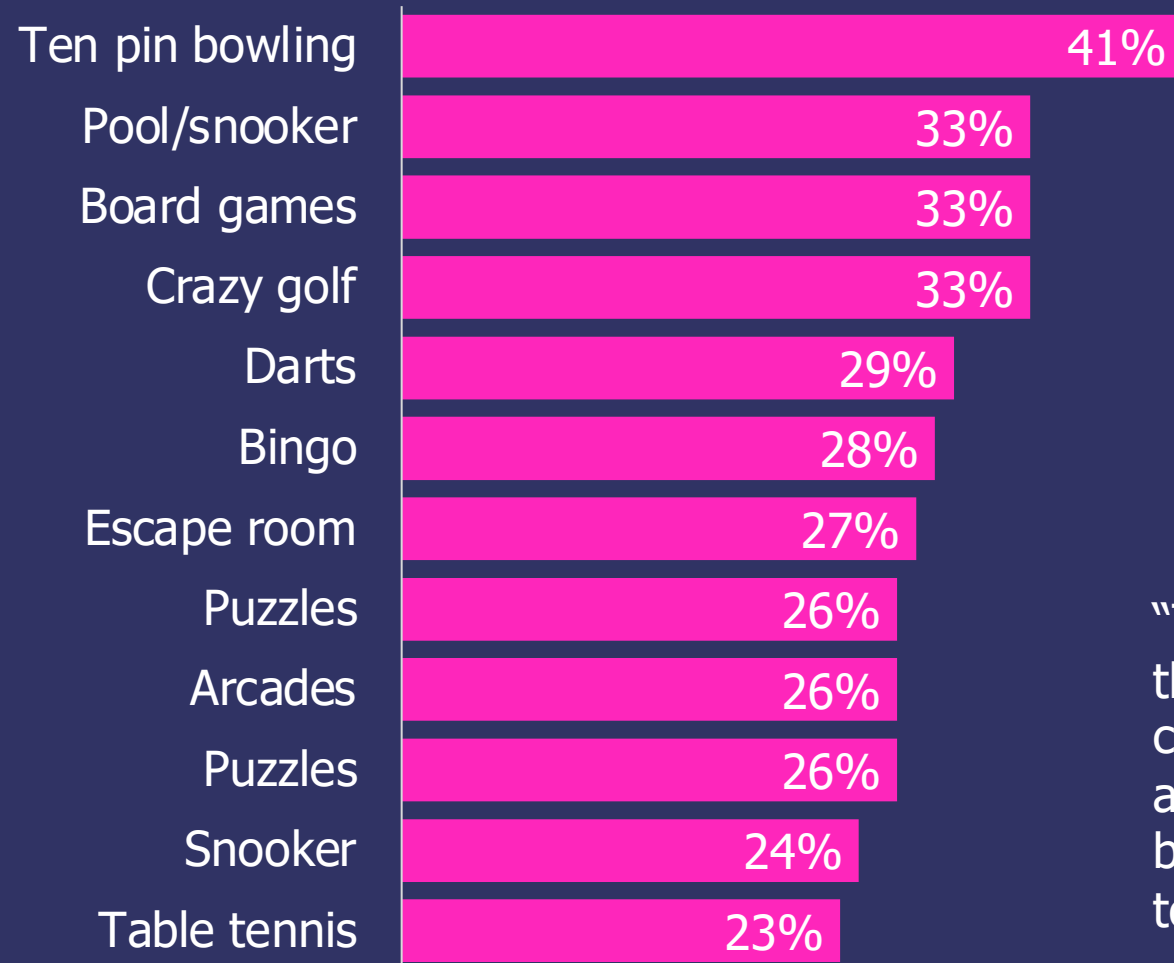
**Of Gen Z have played a
'game' (e.g. pool, darts, etc.)
in a pub/bar in the last 6
months.**

(Compared to 53% of all UK adults)



“I would like to see more pubs and bars start to offer elements of competitive gaming”





**“The top games
that we want to
see in pubs/
bars”**

“The beauty of competitive socialising and these types of games in general is that they can be simple or they can be technologically advanced. So depending on venue type, budget, etc., most venues can offer a solution to meet customer demand.”

We want to be entertained

Demand is growing. 53% of us are visiting competitive socialising venues MORE now vs 2 years ago. This is highest for Gen Z (67%) but also with families (62%). Meanwhile, 75% of all UK adults would like to see more pubs and bars offer elements of competitive socialising - this could take the form of simply having a selection of board games, to the more traditional darts and pools and all the way up to some more high-tech gaming solutions.

Ultimately, we want to be entertained. Whilst it can be said that atmosphere is what you make of it – customers don't want to do all the work themselves to ensure they have a good time.

In fact, 60% of customers believe it's the pub/bar's responsibility to ensure they have a memorable experience when they visit.



"

As our members navigate their recovery they will need to take every opportunity to grow trade. In the post pandemic world, customers are seeking a fantastic experience and not just food & drink. What is clear is that whatever experience they deliver it will have to be done brilliantly to attract and retain customers.

"

Steve Alton
Chief Executive Officer · BII



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Summary

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Competitive Socialising is here to stay. It's a way in which operators can create more of an "experience" for the customer- leading to higher dwell times and a larger in-venue spend. But there are some watch-outs- we must make sure that alongside the bells and whistles, we're still satisfying customer demand for good quality food and drink- and of course, that hospitable service that our industry is so well known for. Operators who get this right will not only gain more customers but also help to foster a loyalty within their customer base. And let's not think that this emerging trend is just for the younger crowd- research shows that a whole mix of demographics are interested in participating- don't forget the likes of the older generation (bored of being stuck at home, looking for something 'new') and of course families, who value anything that keeps the kids occupied and happy

”

Katy Moses
MD and Founder, KAM

COMPETITIVE SOCIALISING

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